

Over-farming

Too many crops take nutrients and water out of the soil. This means new plants are not able to survive in the soil.

Areas around today's deserts are most at risk of desertification.

Rain doesn't fall during a drought, which affects plants.

Global warming

A hotter planet could cause desertification in lots of ways. For example, some crops don't grow as well in hotter weather. Less rainfall also leads to dry soil that blows away.

Desertified soil is too loose for plants to anchor their roots in properly.

Over 100 countries are at risk of desertification.

Desertified land

Few things grow in sand. It also holds less carbon than fertile soil. If carbon is released into the air as a gas, it traps heat and can speed up global warming.

Tackling the problem

People are looking at ways of using desertified land. In some areas, plants can be grown in holes called zai pits. These collect water and can be filled with nutrient-rich animal poo or soil.

Zai pits